

Academia

“It’s Not About How Many Companies You Incubate—It’s About How Many Are Still Standing Five Years Later.”

Is IIT-M’s Pravartak just another incubator for startups? Or is it different? To answer that, EFY’s Akanksha spoke to Shankar Raman from Pravartak, and here is what she discovered...

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What sets Pravartak’s incubation model apart, and how do you measure its success?

We go beyond offering funding and space. Our team embeds with startups, guiding them daily for up to two years. Each incubatee must validate market fit through IIT-M’s Gopalakrishnan-Deshpande Centre cohort programme. Co-development with faculty and industry experts ensures real-world relevance. Our approach is hands-on, with strong customer and VC connections. The goal is not how many companies we incubate, but how many still stand five years later, a true measure of impact. At Pravartak, we build survivability through funding strategies, customer connections, and business model refinement.

How do you support startups beyond incubation?

When startups lack business or marketing capability, we assign in-house experts to represent their product, for a nominal fee. This reinforces the principle that every service has value, and financial discipline is essential.

How do you support startups beyond incubation, especially to cross the valley of death?

That phase, typically in years

three to five, is where many startups fail due to lack of cash flow. We have learned from IIT Madras Research Park (IITMRP) that the key is to ensure cash inflow by year two. We do this by facilitating early service contracts or pilot deployments. Once cash starts flowing, their survival chances increase significantly.

Do you nurture student-led startups and tap ideas of IITians?

Yes, we actively nurture student-led startups—especially those emerging from IIT Madras’s Centre for Innovation (CFI). CFI is a hub where students build proof-of-concept projects. We scout these early ideas, and if they show promise and market potential, we bridge them to customers or bring them under Pravartak or the IITM Research Park for incubation. While we do not incubate all sectors, such as healthcare or rural tech, we focus heavily on deep-tech domains such as sensors, actuators, networking, and control systems. Startups like Folium Sensing (optical sensors), Rio Systems (wireless sensing), and others working on electrical wave-based sensing are examples we have supported. We offer strategic handholding at every stage, from concept to commercialisation, ensuring innovation does not remain confined to the lab.

What founder traits do you seek, and how do you balance tech and market fit?

Passion, adaptability, and customer empathy. We value founders who persist through failure, are open to changing their core idea based on feedback, and truly listen to customers, traits more critical than the technology itself. Many startup pitch decks forecast revenue for 2025 or beyond, but to us, that is just paper. What matters is: can your product genuinely solve a customer’s problem? If yes, the business will grow organically.

How do local needs drive innovation at IITM Pravartak?

India’s context is fundamentally different. For instance, 5G was originally designed for high-speed transport in Western countries, like cars travelling at 300km/hr on autobahns. But in India, most people travel by autos, two-wheelers, or bicycles at 50-100km/hr. So why import that model blindly? Our approach is to develop India-specific, cost-effective solutions. Local problems demand local innovation, and that is not ‘jugaad’; it is intelligent adaptation. For example, we are working on low-cost digital telescopes for cardiac diagnostics. Instead of the standard ₹85,000+ systems, we are targeting